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VICES AND VIRTUES TOUR III

FORGIVE ME FATHER

The camera opens just beyond the curtain.

Through a small gap, Boone Carter can be seen in the ring for the contract signing. The show has already moved on.

Lena Wilde sits on a road case nearby, bruised, bloodied and still trying to catch her breath. One arm rests against her body after the beating Shimoda put it through.

For a moment, she just sits there with herself.

A backstage interviewer approaches.

INTERVIEWER: "Lena?"

Lena looks up.

INTERVIEWER: "Can I get a word?"

The interviewer glances through the curtain. Then steps a little closer and notices the blood across Lena's face and gear. Her tone softens.

INTERVIEWER: "First... how are you feeling? Are you okay?"

Lena grimaces as she shifts her arm.

LENA: "I've been better."

INTERVIEWER: "Do you need medical?"



LENA WILDE



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Lena shakes her head.

LENA: "They'll find me."

She doesn't seem interested in talking about it.

The interviewer glances through the curtain, then back at Lena.

INTERVIEWER: "You just pinned the UNIQUE World Champion."

That gets more of a reaction.

Lena looks back through the opening.

LENA: "Yeah."

A pause.

LENA: "I did."

INTERVIEWER: "And now, only a few minutes later, they're already out there talking about what comes next."

Lena watches for another moment.

LENA: "That part happened pretty fast."

There's no anger in it. Maybe just a little disbelief.

LENA: "Last week I couldn't stop looking at my name next to his."

She lets out a tired breath.

LENA: "Now I beat him and somehow I'm already sitting behind the curtain watching everybody move on."

The interviewer hesitates.

INTERVIEWER: "Does that bother you?"

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Lena finally looks away from the ring.

LENA: "It would if I planned on letting them forget."

A moment.

INTERVIEWER: "There is something people are going to bring up."

Lena knows where this is going.

LENA: "Boone."

INTERVIEWER: "Shimoda had you in the Fujiwara armbar. Boone grabbed Yamamoto, Shimoda lost focus, and that gave you the opening. Do you think that takes anything away from this win?"

Lena answers immediately.

LENA: "No."

No hesitation.

LENA: "Did Boone give me an opening? Yeah. I'm not gonna stand here and pretend everybody didn't see it."

She adjusts the wrist tape on her bad arm.

LENA: "But Boone Carter didn't fight out of that armbar."

A beat.

LENA: "Boone didn't hit Bleed Out."

She looks directly at the interviewer now.

LENA: "And he damn sure didn't hit it twice."

The exhaustion is still there...

Something sharper pushes through it.

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LENA: "I busted the World Champion open. I survived everything he threw at me. And when he gave me one second... I took it."

A pause.

LENA: "That doesn't taint anything."

She looks through the curtain again.

INTERVIEWER: "So what does tonight mean to you?"

Lena thinks about it. Her eyes drift through the curtain again.

LENA: "Last week I couldn't stop staring at my name next to his."

A tired smile.

LENA: "Carried the damn card around like it meant something."

She pushes herself off the road case, grimacing as she gets to her feet.

LENA: "I don't need the card anymore."

A pause.

LENA: "Now it's in the record."

She looks back toward the ring.

LENA: "Lena Wilde beat Devil Shimoda."

Then she walks away.

She turns and starts walking away as the arena noise swells behind the curtain.

A moment later, one guttural shout cuts through everything.

DEVIL SHIMODA: "CARTER DIES."